

ALEJANDRO VELÁZQUEZ

Lead Product Designer & Design Manager

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SUMMARY

Product design leader with 20+ years in fintech, open banking, payments and platform SaaS across Europe and Latin America. Founding designer at Yapily, where I built the design function from nothing and now lead a team of two across the platform.

I work best on products where the experience isn't fully under design's control — regulated flows, API-first platforms, third-party dependencies — and where improvement has to be measured rather than asserted. Most of what I'm proudest of at Yapily is the apparatus: a research practice, event instrumentation and an in-house experimentation pipeline built alongside the design work, because without them there was no way to prove a change had helped.

EXPERIENCE

Lead Product Designer & Design Manager — Founding Designer

Jan 2020 – Present

Yapily — London — open banking infrastructure across the UK and Europe

Joined as the company's first designer and built the design function. Now manage two product designers, owning hiring, onboarding and performance reviews; seven designers managed across six years as the team changed shape.

HOSTED PAGES — WHITE-LABEL CONSENT AND BANK-CONNECTION FLOW

- Led strategy, design and launch of Hosted Pages, spanning 1,500+ banks across 10+ countries at launch — over 2,000 across 19 countries today. Reduced customer integration effort from around six months to two weeks. Now used by 200 companies, including Google, Adyen, Intuit, Ant Financial and Revolut.
- End-to-end conversion rose from around 20% at the 2023 beta to 65–75% today, varying by use case and market — moved incrementally over three years by UX, frontend and backend together, alongside expanding bank coverage. Design's share isn't cleanly separable from infrastructure gains, and I don't claim the figure as a design result.
- **Bank selection: time to find a bank fell from 5–15 seconds to 1–3 in most markets, and 3–5 in branch-heavy ones** — through brand grouping, a popular-banks shortcut, display names matched to what people call their bank, and search alias gaps passed to engineering. Commissioned benchmarking had put competitors at 1–3 seconds.
- Other measurable movements: **embedded login, roughly 13%** (bank-specific field mapping corrected through testing, A/B tested trust signals, and per-bank retry limits); and the **decoupled QR handoff, roughly 10%** in the regions where it was retained. Both directional, from overlapping production experiments rather than isolated tests.
- Three of the most valuable research findings weren't screen problems: bank display names didn't match what people call their bank; the search index held no aliases or retired brand names; and our retry handling enforced limits banks didn't actually impose. Each went to engineering as a data or logic change rather than a design change.
- Established that app-to-app authentication was a regional capability rather than a default. Where coverage was thin and banks issued competing QR codes, the change was removing our QR step rather than explaining it better — and conversion improved.
- Led accessibility work to WCAG AA. A commissioned audit found contrast failures and screen readers announcing raw SVG markup because alternative text was implemented incorrectly, leaving the flow unnavigable by screen reader. We postponed a release to fix both rather than ship and correct later; I documented the findings for the frontend team and the product now meets AA. A separate unmoderated study of 21 testers in Germany, including participants with disabilities, found 62% preferred the redesigned flow, rising to 78% among testers with disabilities.

RESEARCH, INSTRUMENTATION AND EXPERIMENTATION

- Built the research practice with no dedicated research function: 200+ customer interviews at a sustained monthly cadence since 2020, and a 2023–2026 programme of hundreds of end-user usability sessions, sized to the decision in each case.
- Commissioned usability, accessibility and competitor benchmarking studies through Testbirds and Applause; guerrilla testing for early iterations. Matched method cost to decision cost.
- Mapped the event instrumentation with engineering and product, then defined the experimentation pipeline with product and built it in-house — enabling A/B testing against production traffic, and making the conversion claims above possible at all.
- Set up a bi-weekly feedback forum and shared prioritisation board with product, customer success, support and engineering. Restructured the documentation information architecture through card sorting, testing findability before and after.

CONSOLE, DESIGN SYSTEMS AND PLATFORM

- Mapped the end-to-end customer journey across sales, customer success, technical services, support and operations, and led the information architecture for the Console redesign that followed. Ran a two-day hackathon with engineering, product and implementation, role-playing as an outside consultancy using only what a real customer can access, to surface onboarding blockers.
- The Console began in 2020 as a certificate vault and application manager for customers holding their own open banking licence. It was extended in 2022 for Yapily Connect and thousand-bank markets, then rebranded repeatedly without new functionality while engineering migrated from a monolith to microservices — until the API had outpaced it.

Every gap was absorbed by people: CSMs, PMs and support manually enabling features, curating bank coverage and communicating bank capabilities.

- Split the path rather than replacing it: enterprise customers keep an assisted journey, everyone else gets self-serve — removing support as a default dependency rather than removing support. The 2026 beta covers KYB online, own bank portfolio, performance and billing visibility, team invites and integration tooling, with no conversation required at any step. In beta; too early for adoption metrics.
- Modelled customer structure properly for the first time: multiple organisations for customers operating across regions, and sub-applications for customers who resell to their own customers.
- The Hosted Pages configurator shipped in full, giving customers self-serve control over every screen — previously a support ticket and an engineer per request.
- Built three design systems from scratch for different consumers — internal tools, the white-label customer-facing foundation, and the marketing site — documented in Storybook and Figma on a three-tier token layer, now built against by around 38 engineers and 4 designers. The white-label system shares components with the internal one but inherits no brand, which is what makes customer self-serve theming possible without editing a component. Built the contribution and approval governance jointly with the frontend lead, and handed each established system to a designer on the team.
- Wrote Yapily's open banking UX guidance for customers building their own experiences — end-to-end flows, consent screens, consent dashboards, return experiences, re-consent journeys and checkouts — delivered as documentation plus interactive demos.
- Set the vision and problem framing for demo.yapily.com, led its design and maintain it with my team — an indexed library of live demo journeys running real end-to-end flows against mock and live banks, used in implementation, sales and RFI conversations.
- Led design across six rebrands and the yapily.com homepage redesign with marketing and two external agencies, and lead the team producing brand and sales collateral behind go-to-market.
- Partnered with executive leadership on product strategy, prioritisation and platform vision, and supported the compliance team on FCA presentations. Worked with designers and product managers at Google over two years — the first year helping them build their own bank selection and authentication flows, after which they adopted Hosted Pages for account verification and for markets where per-market complexity made building it themselves uneconomic. Currently leading migration of the design systems into AI tooling as part of a company-wide AI transformation.

Lead Product Designer

2019

HeadBox — London — enterprise event technology and SaaS platform

- Led product design through a leadership transition with no reliable way to measure product performance. Fifteen customer interviews refocused the team on the enquiry-to-booking funnel, where only 20% of enquiries received a host proposal.
- Shipped the Enquiry Hub as a deliberately small experiment — London only, capped at £10k — which showed the platform connected hosts and guests well but converted poorly, and led to the pivot from marketplace to SaaS lead generation.
- Research established that expertise sat on the wrong side of the transaction: guests were making expert decisions while venue hosts, the actual experts, received unmatched leads they couldn't act on. Inverted the model — guests complete a requirements wizard, hosts choose from a lead feed — which changed the revenue model from sales commission to paid access and removed the incentive for off-platform leakage.
- Designed and launched the company's first SaaS product for venue partners, generating £150,288 ARR from 117 customers within three months — four times the prior model's performance. 1,500+ leads in the first month, with hosts logging in daily from launch after previous tools had failed to get them to log in at all. The wizard remains HeadBox's primary entry point seven years later.
- Established the design system, governance framework and research practice used across the organisation.

Senior Product Designer (Contract)

Nov 2016 – Dec 2018

Docomo Digital — London — global payments and commerce infrastructure

- Led design for NOMO, a marketplace payments platform supporting merchant onboarding, compliance, wallet management and automated vendor payouts through APIs.
- Designed payment, payout and reconciliation experiences for international marketplaces and sharing-economy platforms, simplifying workflows involving settlements, merchant management and international payments. Collaborated with product, service design and engineering teams across Europe and Asia.

Lead Product Designer (Contract)

2017 – 2018

Caremoni / My Support Broker — London — NHS personal health budget payments (concurrent side engagement)

- Interviewed every party in the chain — operators, independent carers, care agencies and people receiving care — then ran a concierge pilot with a plain front end and payments still processed by hand. It corrected a wrong assumption about digital confidence and reframed the problem as admin burden.
- Designed an operator dashboard for budget allocation, spend monitoring and NHS reporting, plus an app for carers and customers to request and authorise payments. Reached MVP and ran as a pilot with a subset of customers.

Lead Product Designer

Oct 2013 – 2016

Payfriendz — London — digital wallet and peer-to-peer payments

- Directed mobile and web experience design across multiple releases with two designers and fifteen engineers, working with founders on product strategy and platform evolution. Built the UI component system and mentored support staff into research roles.
- Introduced user research and usability testing practices that informed prioritisation. £5M+ transferred by 150,000+ users; ranked #1–3 in the Apple App Store finance category.

Product Designer (Contract)

Jan 2013 – Oct 2013

Payango — Berlin — worked remotely from Philadelphia, USA

- Designed user experiences for prepaid card, digital banking and payment products.

Designer

Aug 2011 – Nov 2012

Andimol — Argentina, then remote from the USA

- Interaction design and UX/UI consultancy for Latin American firms.

Design Analyst

Sep 2008 – Aug 2011

Globant — Argentina

- Designed enterprise products and digital experiences for organisations including Google, JP Morgan, PwC, Coca-Cola, Telefónica and Travelocity, within multidisciplinary product and engineering teams.

Earlier

2005 – 2008

Sysnet Mexico, Datasigma & independent — Argentina

- Motion design for Nokia HQ information screens; web design in CSS, HTML and CMS with direct client relationships; freelance design for small and medium businesses.

EDUCATION

Escuela Da Vinci — Multimedia & Web Design · 2002 – 2005

Universidad de Buenos Aires — Human Resources (Relaciones Laborales) · 1999 – 2003

SKILLS

Design Leadership · Product Strategy · Product Discovery · Open Banking · Payments · Platform & API-first Products · Developer Experience · Enterprise SaaS · Design Systems · Design Operations · User Research · Experimentation & A/B Testing · Accessibility (WCAG AA) · Stakeholder Management · HTML, CSS & JavaScript